

Wired LAN v/s Wi-Fi

Is it time to replace the conventional wired LAN with a Wi-Fi network? Find out...

Transition to Wi-Fi with the added burden of logistics and management is not feasible

ICICI bank has a network of 505 branches and more than a 1000 ATMs in the country. It also has its presence in UK, Canada, Singapore, and other countries. ICICI chiefly uses wired Local Area Network (LAN) for its scale of operations.

"Almost all the ICICI offices work on wired LAN. As a bank we do not need to have a complete Wi-Fi setup because the staff would prefer to work on desktop computers rather than laptops. Besides, Wi-Fi definitely works better with laptops and just for the sake of having a Wi-Fi connection we cannot afford to replace our existing desktops with new laptops.

Photograph: Mexy Xavier



Pravir Vohra
Chief Technology Officer,
ICICI Bank

Banks function on closed networks, where it is not advisable to have Wi-Fi connectivity

"However, a few of our branches do use Wi-Fi in areas such as conference rooms and training centres to name a few. Since we are using wired LAN at the moment, the transition to Wi-Fi and the added burden of logistics and management is not be feasible.

"Another major concern for us is security. If an outsider gains access to our customers' account or to insider information, the damage could be colossal. Banks function on closed networks, where it is not advisable to have Wi-Fi connectivity.

"Nevertheless, we are using Wi-Fi as a pilot run in some branches. For instance, at these branches, we provide our hostesses with a tablet PC and they assist customers who are waiting in queues by solving their queries and doubts. Through Wi-Fi, they can tell account holders whether their cheque has been cleared or not, prepare drafts and provide other similar services. This method prevents queuing as customers are not required to go to the counter any more.

"Such experiments are being conducted using Wi-Fi. Further deployment of Wi-Fi in our branches will depend on various parameters, an important one being customer feedback. Having said that, I still feel Wi-Fi will not replace our wired LAN office environment."

In terms of expenditure, Wi-Fi will prove to be more reasonable and effective than wired LAN

A five star hotel in Mumbai, Hotel Marine Plaza has a lodging capacity of 68 rooms. Though the rooms are yet to be Wi-Fi (Wireless Fidelity) enabled, all the restaurants, business rooms and terraces at Marine Plaza are Wi-Fi hotspots.

"We are living in an era where there is a constant need to stay connected, not only to our workplaces but also various other setups worldwide. Wi-Fi comes to your rescue in such cases. At Marine Plaza, we access the wireless Internet service through Wi-Fi technology. Guests staying at the hotel have access to a high-speed wireless Internet connection.

Photograph: Jiten Gandhi



Anurag Bajaj
General Manager,
Hotel Marine Plaza

Our business needs to be completely Wi-Fi enabled in order to function better

"Along with EZ-COMM, our provider for Wi-Fi access, we have adopted a model, which eliminates most of the disturbances that occur in a typical LAN network and we are able to have an uninterrupted Internet connection. We can offer our guests a broadband connection of 512 Kbps. Moreover, they have the facility to buy prepaid cards that can be used at any of the EZ-COMM wireless locations across India.

"An organisation may function in different time zones, and at times it becomes unavoidable to do official work from home or even during vacation. Some guests may be on a business trip. We also have international guests staying at the Marine Plaza. It is true that many customers prefer to stay with us as they consider the availability of Wi-Fi connectivity an added advantage to their package.

"Altogether, we have six floors including the ground floor of our building on wired LAN network. That apart, most of our guest area is equipped with Wi-Fi for Internet access. I believe that our business needs to be completely Wi-Fi enabled to function better. Wi-Fi will definitely help us serve our customers better. In terms of expenditure, Wi-Fi will work out to be more reasonable and effective than wired LAN."

As told to Preethi Chamikutty (preethi_chamikutty@thinkdigit.com)